

Chapter 43

The drive proved considerably longer than William had expected.

He didn't mind.

England beyond London became softer somehow. The buildings gradually gave way to villages, hedgerows, rolling fields, and ancient stone cottages that seemed as though they'd always belonged exactly where they stood.

He barely noticed any of it.

He was simply happy to be beside Claire.

The previous evening had unfolded so differently than either of them had imagined.

Not because anything extraordinary had happened.

Quite the opposite.

Once the nervousness disappeared...

Once they stopped worrying about the moment...

The moment quietly became itself.

Gentle.

Affectionate.

Sweet.

The act itself hadn't transformed either of them.

It rarely did.

It was everything afterward.

The quiet conversations.

The laughter.

The comfortable silence.

The realization that they had entrusted one another with something deeply personal and discovered nothing had changed except how safe they felt together.

There was a new ease between them now.

A comfort.

And, if William was being completely honest with himself...

A growing desire to find that closeness again whenever life allowed.

For now...

Simply sitting beside her was enough.

Claire rested her head comfortably against his shoulder as the countryside rolled past the window.

Every so often she pointed out a church steeple or a flock of sheep.

William wasn't entirely certain what she'd just shown him.

He'd been looking at her instead.

Antonio was asleep across the rear bench, his quiet snoring rising and falling with the rhythm of the coach.

Rocky occupied the front passenger seat.

His attention remained fixed almost entirely on the windshield.

Traffic.

He hated traffic.

More accurately...

He hated uncertainty.

Schedules existed for a reason.

Traffic ignored them.

The farther west they drove, the thicker the line of vehicles became.

Cars.

Tour buses.

Motorcoaches.

Eventually the highway slowed to little more than a crawl before feeding onto a smaller access road.

The countryside opened around them.

Then...

Off in the distance...

Stonehenge.

Rocky leaned forward.

"...That's it?"

Nobody answered.

He squinted through the windshield.

"It's so..."

He searched unsuccessfully for a kinder word.

"...small."

Antonio stirred just enough to open one eye.

"What is?"

"The famous Stonehenge."

Antonio looked.

"Oh."

Another pause.

"It is kind of just a circle of rocks."

Then he promptly fell asleep again.

Rocky folded his arms.

"I thought it'd be..."

“Bigger?” Claire offered.

“I don’t know.”

He shrugged.

“More.”

William had the distinct impression Rocky was already calculating whether they could simply ask the driver to turn around.

Unfortunately for Rocky...

They had already committed.

The procession of vehicles crept steadily toward the visitor center.

After another several minutes, the driver glanced into the mirror.

“If you don’t mind a short walk...”

All four looked up.

“I can let you off here.”

He pointed toward a footpath stretching gently across the fields.

“You’ll reach the monument much faster on foot than waiting for the coach to park.”

Nobody objected.

The bags remained safely back at the hotel.

There was nothing to carry except cameras and jackets.

The four thanked the driver and stepped into the cool March air.

Claire instinctively slipped her arm through William’s.

The wind carried the scent of fresh grass across the open plain.

Stonehenge slowly grew larger with every step.

Even Rocky admitted...

It looked more impressive from the ground than through the windshield.

The ancient stones stood upon a gentle rise, surrounded by low rope barriers that kept visitors a respectful distance away.

Antonio folded his hands into his jacket pockets.

“I’ve always wanted to see this.”

Rocky looked around.

“I’ve always wanted to say I’ve seen it.”

Claire hardly seemed to hear either of them.

She slowly turned in place.

Taking everything in.

The landscape.

The sky.

The people.

The silence that somehow still existed despite the enormous crowd.

William watched her smile.

He had never seen her quite this captivated before.

He found himself smiling simply because she was.

Beyond the viewing area stood hundreds of neatly arranged white folding chairs.

A large sign welcomed visitors to the Vernal Equinox celebration.

Historical presentations would occur throughout the afternoon.

“Well...” Antonio said.

“We’re here.”

“Might as well stay.”

They found four seats together very close to the front.

Around them families settled into place.

School groups chattered excitedly.

Photographers adjusted lenses.

The atmosphere felt less like a tourist attraction and more like a community gathering.

Near noon...

A single note echoed across the hillside.

Long.

Low.

Haunting.

William looked toward the stones.

Someone had sounded a horn.

It resembled an antler more than any modern instrument.

Conversation across the audience gradually faded.

From beyond the rise, a long procession slowly appeared.

Dozens became scores.

Scores became hundreds.

Actors dressed as ancient druids made their way across the landscape in solemn silence.

Some wore animal hides.

Others long black cloaks that moved gently in the breeze.

Above them, a narrator's voice drifted from concealed loudspeakers.

It spoke of the ancient monument.

The changing seasons.

The vernal equinox.

The people who had once gathered upon this very ground thousands of years before.

Claire couldn't decide where to look.

Every few moments something else caught her attention.

A ceremonial staff.

An elaborate headdress.

Painted faces.

Children participating alongside seasoned performers.

William smiled.

She looked happier than she'd been all week.

The procession gradually divided.

One line approached from the east.

The other from the west.

Like two rivers flowing toward one another.

Slowly...

Gracefully...

They passed through each other.

The lines weaving together before continuing onward.

Only one figure remained still.

A solitary man stood motionless near the center.

Unlike the others, he wore a long black cloak.

Its hood completely concealed his face.

The rest of the procession flowed around him.

Then continued onward.

One by one...

The actors disappeared beyond the far rise.

The narrator fell silent.

The audience applauded politely.

Only the solitary figure remained.

He began walking toward the spectators.

Slowly.

Unhurried.

William blinked.

Something...

Something wasn't right.

The grass.

It seemed...

Greener.

Not brighter.

Greener.

The impossible, vivid green he'd seen before.

The alley.

The dreams.

The same green.

His stomach tightened.

A strange dizziness washed over him.

The applause around him became muffled.

The crowd blurred.

The landscape softened at the edges.

His heartbeat quickened.

The man continued walking.

Closer.

Closer still.

Then...

He reached the edge of the viewing area.

He raised both hands.

Slowly...

He lowered the hood.

William stopped breathing.

He knew that face.

He had seen it countless times.

In dreams.

In photographs.

In memories that somehow weren't his own.

His father.

Before William could force a single word from his mouth—

“Holy shit...”

Rocky was already on his feet.

“It's Vinnie.”